

Chapter

Know Before You Worship — Not Believing, but Knowing



Introduction: Who Is the One We Worship?

Most of us have been worshipping one deity or another since childhood. But have we ever asked who the One we bow before really is? In this short discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji raises exactly this fundamental question:

"If you want to worship God, then who is that Ganesh?
Who is that Devi? Who is that Shiva? Who is that
Vishnu? Who is Lakshmi? Who is Saraswati?"

"And all the rest — Durga or the other gods and goddesses — did you ever try to know them? And if you never even tried to know them, then didn't you simply accept them as God?"

Unknowing Devotion Handed Down from Childhood

Acharya Ji paints a very familiar scene — a child in the home whom the elders teach to bow before Ganapati:

"Forcefully, from childhood — 'Say Bappa to him, Bappa.' So, 'Yes, yes, it's Bappa, it's Bappa, namaskar Bappa.' They bowed, so I bowed too."

Bappa — the affectionate name by which Lord Ganesh is called in Maharashtra.

That bow came from imitation, not understanding. And the questions never arose:

"Why did I do it? Don't know. How did he become Bappa? Don't know. Why call him Bappa? Don't know. Why is he in the form of an elephant? Why not in the form of a horse, why not something else? Never asked this."

And then Acharya Ji's direct question:

"So will this do?"

The Example of Child Marriage: Relationships Made in Ignorance

To explain this, Acharya Ji takes the example of marriage. In the old days there were child marriages, where the relationship was fixed first and understanding came later:

"In earlier times there used to be child marriages. It was decided in childhood, and only after growing up would one understand who is my wife, who is my husband."

Why was that custom abandoned? Because a relationship joined without knowing was not considered right:

"So why was that custom stopped? Because it did not seem proper, did it? **Relationships made in a state of ignorance will not be proper.**"

Our relationship with God is just like this — joined in childhood without understanding, and never understood even after growing up.

Love from Just a Photo?

Then Acharya Ji gives another vivid example — as though someone suddenly found a photo lying somewhere:

"Someone just gave you a photo, suddenly; in a newspaper or fallen somewhere, or you found a photo of some girl somewhere else, and immediately you can say, 'Oh wow, I love her! She is my girlfriend from today' — does that ever happen?"

"You only saw a photo; you saw nothing of the real person. 'That's it, I have to marry her.' Who she is, what she is, where she is — don't know. What her name is — don't know."

And yet the mind takes it as settled:

"Someone said, 'Her name is so and so.' 'Yes, she's the one, it's fixed.' So you'll sit there saying 'fixed, fixed, fixed' — will that do?"

"'It's my love, I've fallen in love.' Arre, but with whom did it happen? You don't even know the person. Where she lives — don't know. Who her parents are — don't know. But just, I liked her, I fell in love."

In worldly life this immediately seems absurd to us. Yet in spirituality we do exactly this.

The Same Rule in Spirituality

Acharya Ji says clearly that what holds true for marriage holds true for spirituality as well:

"As much importance as that has, the same importance has been given in spirituality. **If you don't even know your God, merely believing does not work.**"

"'I have accepted Ganapati as my God' — then that accepting has become just like that photo."

And then the deepest point of this discourse — a relationship goes both ways:

"'I have accepted this girl as my wife.' Arre, but has she accepted you as her husband? Are you understanding a little? **The other side must also agree to that relationship, no?**"

A relationship with God is not formed merely by our accepting Him. It is complete when God too accepts us as His own — and whom He accepts, He has told us Himself.

The Knowing Devotee: Dearest to God

Acharya Ji points to the scriptures:

"So Krishna himself is telling us in the Gita — in the Bhagavad Gita; in the Ganesh Gita, Ganesh himself is telling us. In his entire Purana and all the other scriptures, Ganesh says just this much: **the knowing devotee is extremely dear to me.**"

In the Bhagavad Gita, Shri Krishna says it this way:

**teṣāṁ jñānī nitya-yukta eka-bhaktir viśiṣyate
priyo hi jñānino 'tyartham ahaṁ sa ca mama
priyaḥ**

"Among them, the knower — ever united with Me,
devoted to the One alone — is the best; for I am
exceedingly dear to the knower, and he is dear to
Me."

— Bhagavad Gita 7.17

And Acharya Ji opens up the meaning of the knowing devotee in a single sentence:

"Gyani bhakt means — one who knows me very well."

"So it said to know, it did not say to believe."

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 Before worship, this question is essential — **who is the One I am worshipping?** Ganesh, Shiva, Vishnu, Devi — we should make the effort to know them.
- 2 A bow made only out of imitation since childhood is not connected to understanding; asking "why" is necessary.
- 3 Just as **relationships made in a state of ignorance** were not considered proper, a relationship with God formed without knowing is incomplete.
- 4 **Merely accepting God without knowing Him** is just like falling in love from seeing a photo.
- 5 A relationship goes both ways — **the other side must also agree to that relationship.**
- 6 Both Shri Krishna and Shri Ganesh say that **the knowing devotee is extremely dear to them** — the one who knows them well.

7 The scriptures told us to know, not merely to believe.